A large breakfast with members of Senate and House teams who are going to Geneva for opening of arms talks plus our negotiators. There seemed to be a feeling of unity even including Senator Ted Kennedy. Then over to the Roosevelt Room and we had formal send off. . . then it was off to Bethesda Naval Hospital for my annual check up. I'm so healthy I had a hard time not acting smug.

March 11

Awakened at 4 a.m. to be told Chernenko is dead. My mind turned to whether I should attend the funeral. My gut instinct said no. Got to the office at 9. George Shultz had some arguments that I should. He lost. I don't think his heart was really in it. George Bush is in Geneva. He'll go and George Shultz will join him leaving tonight.

Word has been received that Gorbachev has been named head man in the Soviet Union.

So, once again, there was a new man in the Kremlin. "How am I supposed to get anyplace with the Russians," I asked Nancy, "if they keep dying on me?"